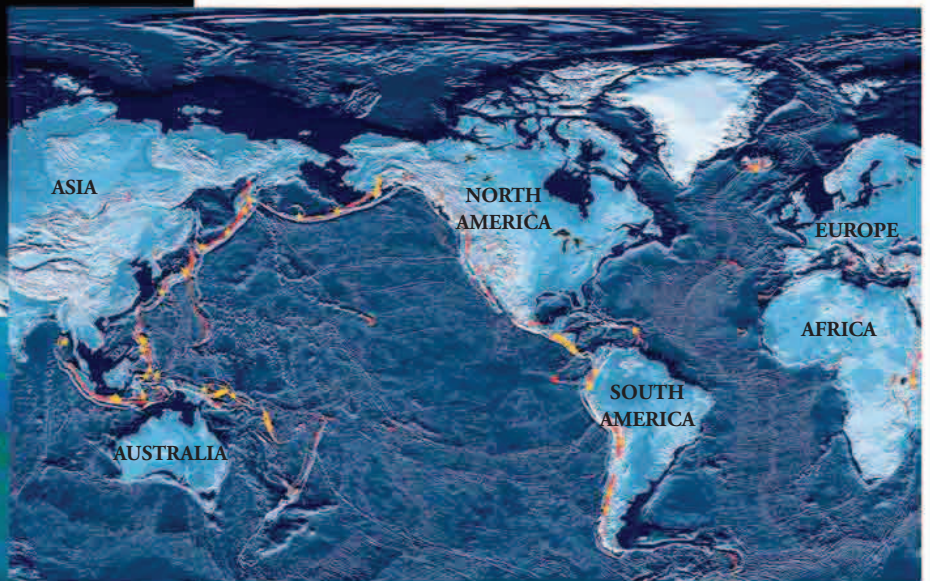




KEY ● Most active volcanoes

● Volcanoes and earthquakes

RING OF FIRE

Most of the planet's subduction zones lie on the edges of the giant Pacific Ocean. They have created a ring of deep ocean trenches around the Pacific, fringed by a chain of more than 450 volcanoes—the Pacific Ring of Fire.

The relentless movement of the plates is gradually destroying the fringes of the ocean floor, shrinking the Pacific Ocean by 1 sq mile (2.5 sq km) a year. It also triggers up to 90 percent of the world's earthquakes.



DANGER ZONES

The subduction zones, where one plate of Earth's crust is grinding beneath another, are notorious for causing earthquakes. Japan lies in one of these regions.

As a result, it suffers more than a thousand earthquakes each year, and every few years a really big earthquake causes massive destruction and loss of life.

